

Suo-Oshima: Nishiyashiro and the Hawaii emigrant villages

Then-and-now aerial photographs, how the ground was made, and the disasters people chose to remember — compiled automatically from public Japanese government data.



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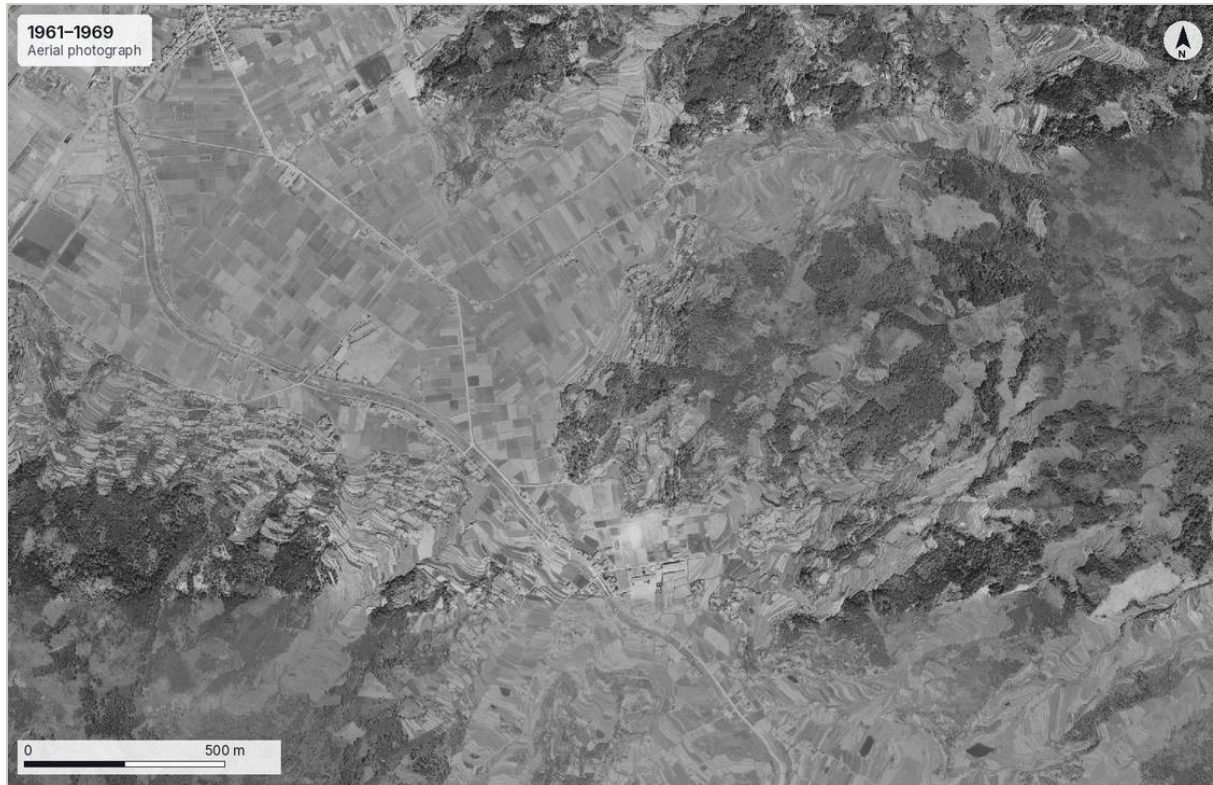
Study area	3.0 km × 1.9 km around 33.9235° N, 132.2045° E
Oldest aerial photograph	1961–1969
Aerial series in this brief	1961–1969, 1974–1978, 1979–1983, latest
Main natural landform	Mountains (61%)
Former river channels	none mapped
Filled, reclaimed or drained land	none mapped
Former sea, river or pond	none mapped
Meiji-era paddies, marsh and flats	rice paddy 17%, salt pans 1.3%
Disaster memorials within 3 km	3 (flood 3, landslide or debris flow 3)

What this brief is. A reading aid for comparing the same ground across decades. It shows what the photographs and GSI's land surveys record; it does not describe current conditions, access or opening hours.

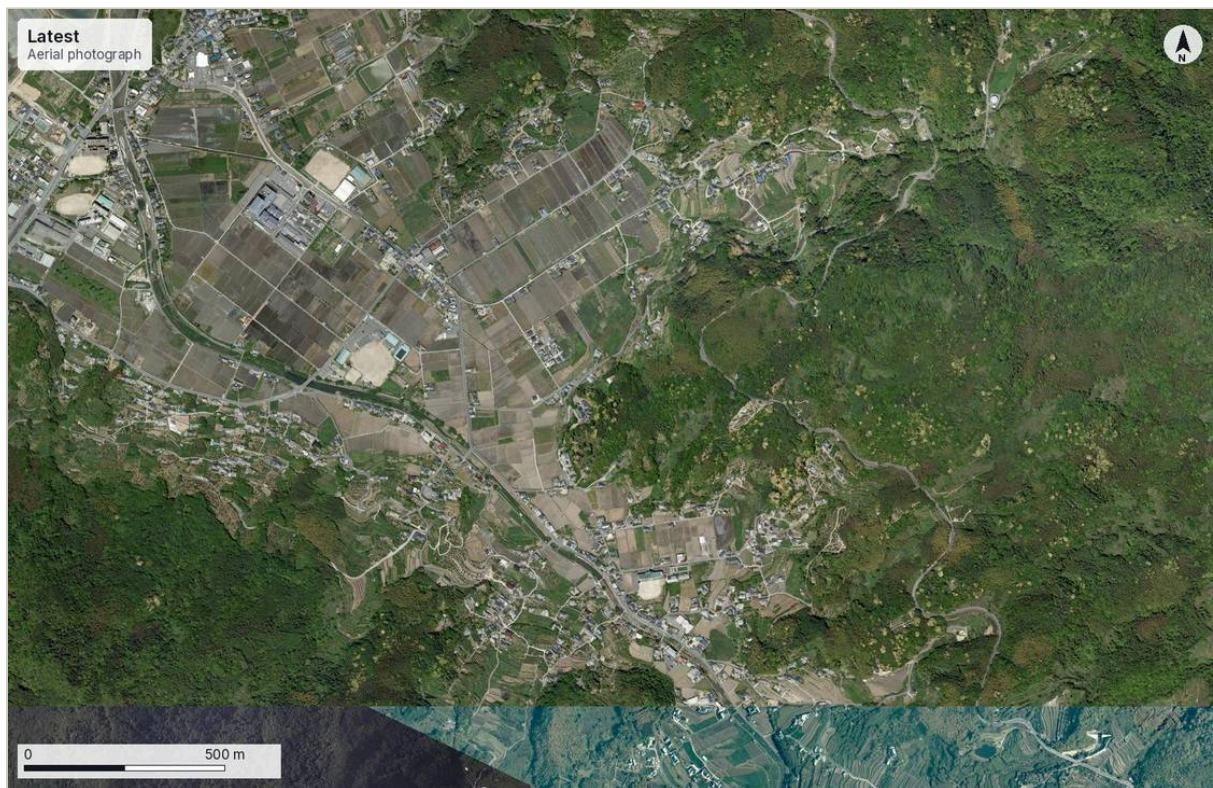
What it is not. Not a hazard assessment or a property survey. Landform classes describe typical tendencies of the ground; for present-day risk, read the official hazard map of the municipality.

Edition 2026-09-27. Aerial photographs, landform and Meiji-era lowland data: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), processed by Japan Time Atlas. Memorial data: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials, summarised and translated by Japan Time Atlas.

The same ground, 1961–1969 and today



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



Latest seamless mosaic — GSI Tiles *seamlessphoto*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

- Mountains 61%
- Lowland 30%
- Residual hills (buttes) 8.6%

GSI has no detailed landform survey for this frame, so the map uses GSI's regional classification (compiled for zoom levels 9–13). It shows the broad landform only; former river channels and man-made ground are not mapped at that scale.

What the main landforms mean

Mountains (61%). Terrain of high ridges and valleys. Watch for slope disasters.

Lowland (30%). Flat land built from sand, gravel and mud laid down by rivers or the sea. River flooding, storm surge and liquefaction; shakes easily in earthquakes.

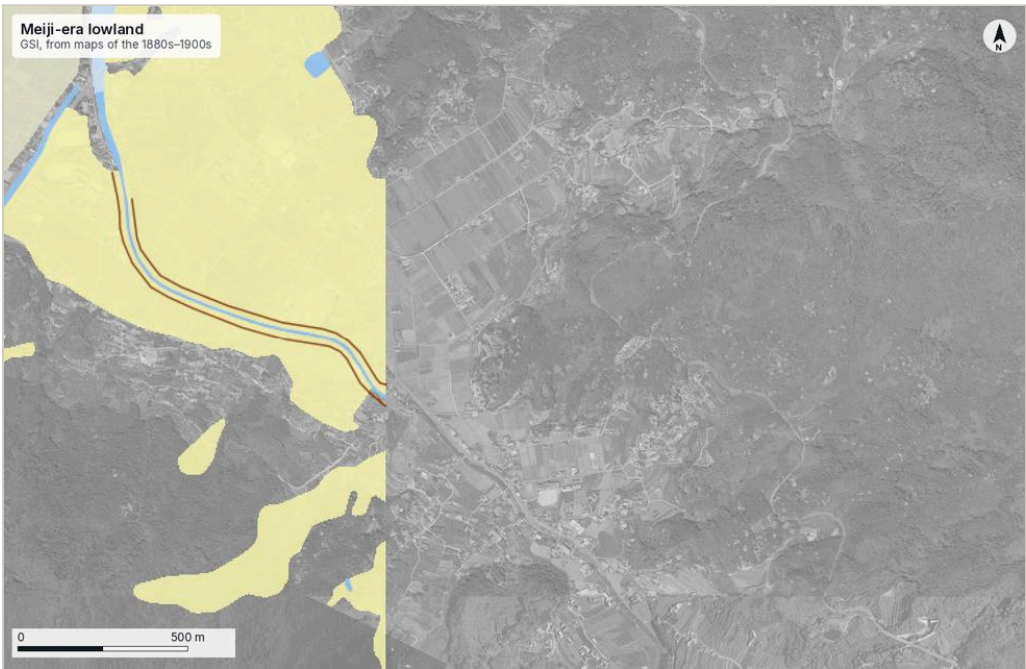
Residual hills (buttes) (8.6%). Isolated rocky peaks or table-like hills of old volcanic rock. Rockfall and slope failures on the surrounding cliffs.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

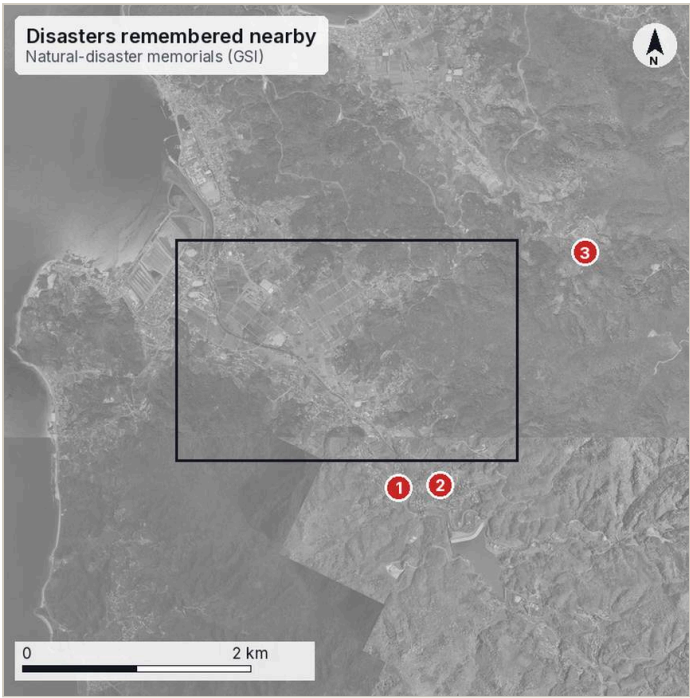
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

- Rice paddy 17%
- Salt pans 1.3%
- River, pond or sea under 0.5%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 6 km across.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Monument to the 1886 Gonotsubo flood disaster 罹災之碑	Great Gonotsubo flood (24 Sep 1886) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1889	1.3 km
2 Memorial to the 110 people killed in the 1886 Gonotsubo flood 弔百十名之霊	Great Gonotsubo flood (24 Sep 1886) · flood / landslide or debris flow	1887	1.4 km
3 Monument to the 1893 flood of the Migama River 水災之碑	Flood (14 Oct 1893) · flood / landslide or debris flow	unknown	2.3 km

What the memorials record

1. **Monument to the 1886 Gonotsubo flood disaster.** Heavy rain every day from about 20 September 1886 set off a landslide that blocked the Kubo River. At 5 pm on the 24th the natural dam burst, and the debris flow killed 110 people in Gonotsubo and buried 62 houses. The inscription notes that the mountain had also collapsed in 1333 and that preventive measures are needed.
2. **Memorial to the 110 people killed in the 1886 Gonotsubo flood.** Heavy rain every day from about 20 September 1886 set off a landslide that blocked the Kubo River and formed a natural dam. At 5 pm on the 24th the dam burst, and the debris flow killed 110 people in Gonotsubo and buried 62 houses.
3. **Monument to the 1893 flood of the Migama River.** On 14 October 1893, after five days of rain, Mount Monju collapsed and the Migama River overflowed. The flood killed 23 people and swept away 16 houses in the former village of Kamano.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Where every element comes from

- **Aerial photographs** (pp. 2–3) — Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), GSI Tiles: series *ort_old10* (1961–1969), *gazo1* (1974–1978), *gazo2* (1979–1983) and *seamlessphoto*. Cropped, resized and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. List of GSI Tiles: <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>
- **Landform classification** (pp. 4–5) — GSI landform-classification vector tiles (natural and artificial landforms), compiled by GSI from its Land Condition Maps, Flood Control Terrain Classification Maps and vulnerable-landform surveys. Rendered, measured and translated into English by Japan Time Atlas. https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification
- **Meiji-era lowland** (p. 5) — GSI “明治期の低湿地” tiles and legend (https://maps.gsi.go.jp/legend/lw_legend.pdf), measured and translated by Japan Time Atlas.
- **Natural disaster memorials** (p. 6) — GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑), registered by municipalities, <https://www.gsi.go.jp/bousaichiri/denshouhi.html>; processed by Japan Time Atlas (selection by distance, English translation and summary). Memorial photographs are not reproduced.
- GSI content is used under the GSI Content Terms of Use, which follow the Public Data License v1.0 (PDL1.0, compatible with CC BY 4.0). Data retrieved 2026-09-27.
- **Outline of Japan** — Data of Japan / JapanPrefGeoJson (public domain), simplified.

Method

The study area is a fixed rectangle of 3.0 × 1.9 km. Every GSI photo series that covers at least 85% of it is included; the newest annual orthophoto covering at least 90% of it is used as “now”, with any gap filled from GSI's latest seamless mosaic. Landform shares are areas of the rectangle measured on GSI's polygons at zoom level 14, each class merged before measuring. Meiji-era shares count map pixels by legend color. Memorials are selected by straight-line distance from the center of the study area.

Limits

Historical series are mosaics of photographs taken on different dates; GSI publishes the flight date of each photograph. Landform data record conditions at the time of survey. Nothing in this brief shows present-day access, safety or opening hours.

Area Dossier. The same district with a 4–8 page English history, written from Japanese library sources and cited page by page.

Deep Research. A single hamlet or address, researched in libraries and archives.

Compiled by Japan Time Atlas; not produced, reviewed or endorsed by GSI, MLIT or any Japanese government agency. Not an official hazard map and not for statutory real-estate disclosure. Generated 2026-09-27 by an automated pipeline ([research/lab-07/scripts/basic.py](#)).